Safety

En analys från Swedish Subsidiarity

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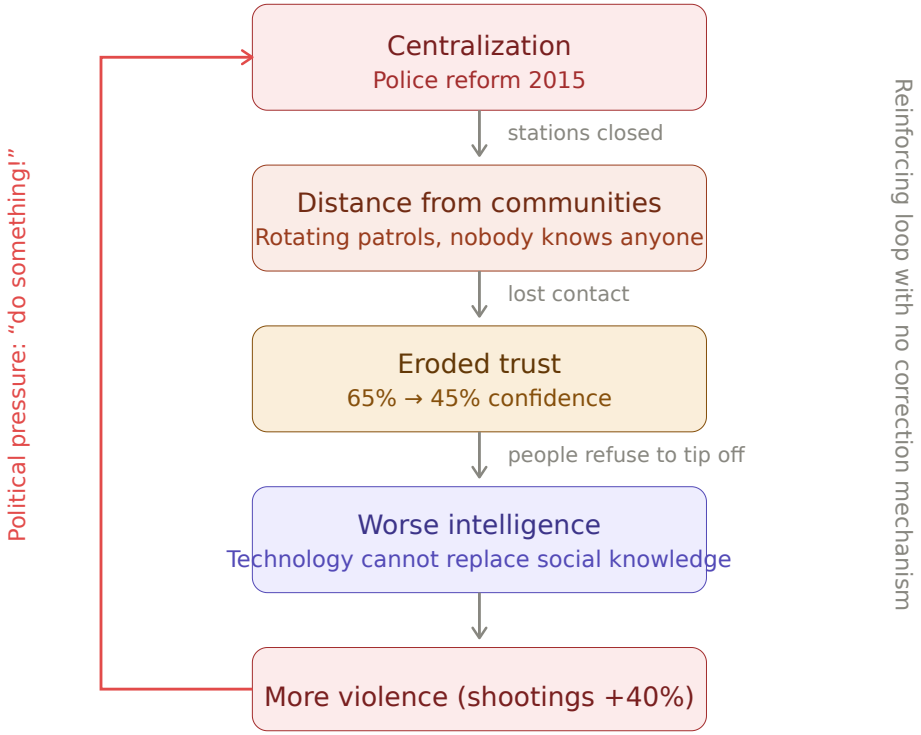
Security and policing: the centralization paradox

The intelligence collapse

Sweden's 2015 police reform centralized 21 authorities into seven regions and closed local stations. The result: shootings and bombings reached record levels, trust in the police in vulnerable areas dropped from 65% (2010) to 45% (2023), and the police solve only 20% of burglaries.

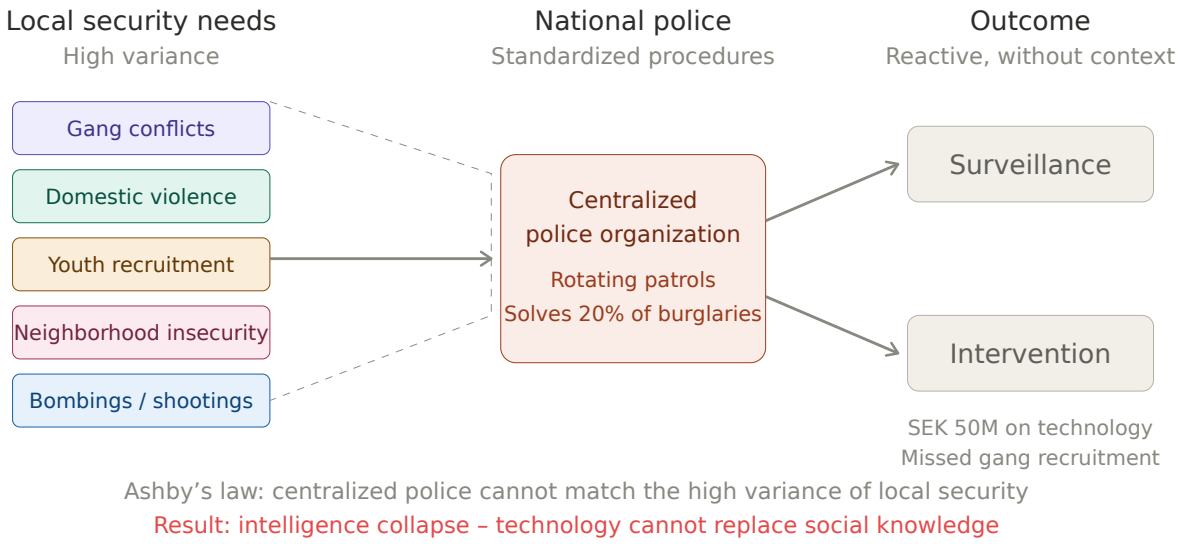
The paradox: Sweden responded to increasing crime with more centralization, larger units, and professional distance. This optimizes for bureaucratic efficiency while destroying the local knowledge that actually creates security. After the station in Rosengård was closed, shootings within a kilometer increased by 40% in twelve months. Local police officers had known 200+ youths by name. New rotating units know no one.

The cybernetic analysis: Security has *high variance* – it arises from local relationships, informal social control, and community knowledge. A national police organization with standardized procedures is a control unit with *low variance*. Attempting to govern local security through centralized professionalization violates Ashby's law. The result: intelligence collapse and escalating violence.



Active system failures (in brief)

- **National reorganization**: The merger severed relationships between police and communities, eliminated local stations, and created rotating duties that prevent relationship building.
- **The designation of vulnerable areas**: Official classification of 61 areas creates stigma and falling property values while resources are directed towards reactive policing, not preventive measures.
- **Intelligence centralization**: SEK 50 million on surveillance technology – but the police missed that a pizzeria was a front for gang recruitment. Technology cannot replace social knowledge.
- **Privatization of security**: Security guards with 80 hours of training patrol shopping centers and squares. Wealthy areas buy their safety while poor ones are abandoned.
- **Professionalization of crime prevention**: The Swedish National Council for Crime Prevention's (Brå) report on gang violence in 2022 contained zero interviews with former gang members or affected families. Professionals exclude lived experience.
- **Monopoly on violence without presence**: The police are absent or distrusted in areas with violence – power vacuums are filled by informal "protectors".



Subsidiarity-based measures

Below are five action areas. Each area has its own page with concrete pilots, budgets, rule changes, and analysis of resistance.

Measure	Short description
→ Security rings	Groups of 50 households sharing concerns, coordinating safe activities, and providing early warning via a secure platform. 4 hours of training, "good samaritan" law.

Measure	Short description
→ Community mediators	100 respected local figures (coaches, religious leaders, grandmothers, former gang members) with 200 hours of training, salary SEK 25,000/month. Intervene in disputes before the police.
→ Municipal security budgets	SEK 100/resident for locally decided security initiatives via participatory budgeting – lighting, youth centers, mediators, de-escalation.
→ Restorative justice	For minor offenses (theft under SEK 5,000, vandalism, fighting), mediation between victim and offender replaces prosecution. Courts can mandate restorative participation.
→ Security centers	Transform fortress-like police stations into integrated hubs: 70% community workers, 30% police. Contains mediation rooms, youth activities, legal help, mental health care.

Implementation: from theory to practice

Phase 1 (1–3 years) – 500 security rings in vulnerable areas. 100 community mediators trained and placed. Open house at 10 police stations with "fika with the police".

Phase 2 (3–7 years) – Municipal security budgets with participatory budgeting. Restorative centers in Tensta, Rosengård, Bergsjön. Monthly police-municipal councils.

Phase 3 (7–15 years) – Transformation of police stations into security centers. 10,000 security guides coordinating prevention. Trained peace teams for non-violent intervention.

Expected resistance and answers

Concern	Response
"Only the state should have authority over security"	Community efforts complement the police, they do not replace them. The police retain the monopoly on violence.
"Community justice bypasses the rule of law"	Serious crimes always go to the formal system. Restorative processes have the right of appeal to court.
"The Swedish Police Union will oppose it"	Police roles evolve towards coordination and mentorship – more meaningful work with less confrontation.
"What if something goes wrong?"	Legal protection for pilots with rigorous evaluation. The risk is continuing with dysfunction, not testing alternatives.

The Swedish advantage

Sweden has **high social trust** (enables community-based methods), **progressive values** (openness to restorative justice), **digital infrastructure** (supports security rings), a **small population** (makes system change feasible), and **municipal self-government** (enables local pilots).

Conclusion: choose between centralized dysfunction and local security

Today's police organization is not under-resourced – it is **architecturally flawed**. Centralization destroyed the local knowledge that is the foundation of all security. Police officers who knew communities, understood relationships, and recognized warning signs were replaced by rotating patrols with no connection.

The choice is simple:

- Continue as today: More surveillance cameras, more central investigation units, more private guards, continued eroded trust, escalating violence.
- Begin the transition: Security rings, community mediators, municipal security budgets, restorative justice, security centers.

Three things you can do tomorrow

If you are a municipal politician: Allocate SEK 200,000 for a pilot with security rings in a residential area with high insecurity. Use the model from this page.

If you are a police officer or local community actor: Start a "fika with the police" evening every month in a local café or library. Get to know your neighbors – that is the best intelligence.

If you are a citizen: Gather 10 neighbors and form a simple security ring – a group chat where you tip each other off about worrying events, coordinate evening walks, and keep an eye on the elderly and children. No police needed – just care.

This analysis applies cybernetic principles (Ashby's law of requisite variety) to the Swedish police system. For deeper measures, click on the links above.

Security rings

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Summary: Groups of 50 households in residential areas forming security rings—an informal network to share concerns, coordinate safe activities, and provide early warning of brewing conflicts or gang recruitment. The participants receive a 4-hour training in observation skills, de-escalation, and appropriate police contact. The rings are supported by a secure digital platform (encrypted chat and anonymous tip function). The goal: to recreate the informal social control and intelligence capacity that the centralization of the police destroyed—at a fraction of the cost of more police patrols.

The mechanism

Today, police intelligence gathering in vulnerable areas is almost non-existent. Local police do not know the residents, rotating patrols do not see the warning signs, and residents do not trust the police enough to provide tips. The result: gangs recruit openly, conflicts escalate into shootings, and no one sees it coming.

The measure: A **security ring** is a loose association of about 50 households in the same residential area or neighborhood that:

- Shares information about worrying events (vandalism, suspicious persons, conflicts between youth) via an encrypted group chat or simple app.
- Coordinates safe activities—evening walks, "night walks" (nattvandringar), open meetings in the community hall—which increases natural surveillance and shows presence.
- Acts as an early warning mechanism: if the ring detects signs of gang recruitment (new expensive clothes, late nights, unknown older individuals), a community mediator or the police's local contact is notified.
- Offers social control without confrontation—neighbors talk to each other's children, ask "whose car is that?", call a parent if something feels wrong.

The training (4 hours, one evening):

- Observation skills: what is normal behavior in the area, what deviates?
- De-escalation: how do you talk to youth without escalating?
- When to contact the police, and how to do it in a way that does not put the tipster in danger?

- Legal protection: what are you allowed and not allowed to do? (No vigilante policing, only observation and reporting.)

The digital platform:

- A simple, secure app (encrypted, two-factor authentication) where ring members can chat, send anonymous tips to a coordinator, and receive information from the police's local contact.
- The platform is owned and operated by an independent foundation, not by the police (to maintain trust). The police only have access to anonymized tips after approval from an independent reviewer.
- The source code is open, so that municipalities and associations can review and improve it.

The difference compared to today's Neighborhood watch (Grannsamverkan):

Aspect	Neighborhood watch (Police)	Security ring
Focus	Residential burglary, theft	Social unrest, gang recruitment, conflicts
Method	Information leaflets, locks, marking	Active chat, night walks, early warning
Digital	Mailing list, simple website	Encrypted app, anonymous tips
Training	None (voluntary info)	4 hours mandatory (to get the tax deduction)
Connection to police	Direct to 114 14	Via community mediator or anonymous tip function

Pilot design – 500 rings first

Pilot phase 1 (years 1-3): 500 security rings in designated vulnerable areas (according to the Police list) and in areas with high insecurity according to local citizen dialogues.

Selection criteria for rings:

- The area has at least 50 households that are interested (registration via municipality or housing company)
- The area has a community hall or similar where training and meetings can be held
- At least 10% of households participate actively (for the ring to reach critical mass)

Organizational model:

- The ring organizes itself: chooses a contact person, determines meeting frequency, creates a chat group.
- The municipality or police provides training (4 hours) via approved trainers (e.g., local mediators, retired police officers, security ambassadors).

- Participants who have completed training and actively participate (reported attendance at at least 75% of meetings or activities) receive a **tax deduction of SEK 2,000/year** ("security deduction").
- Start-up grant per ring: SEK 5,000 to cover coffee, information material, possible venue rental.

State/municipal support:

- A **security coordinator** per municipality (0.5 FTE) is responsible for supporting the rings, connecting them to the police's local contacts, and evaluating the effect.
- The police appoint a **contact police officer** in each area who attends the ring's meetings at least once a quarter (to build trust and receive tips).

Evaluation (compare areas with and without rings):

- Number of reported crimes (vandalism, theft, assault) within the ring's geography
- Number of shootings and bombings (expected to decrease over time)
- Insecurity survey (questionnaire response: "do you feel safe outdoors after dark?")
- Police intelligence quality (number of useful tips, number of arrests based on tips)

Budget and financing

Item	Annual cost (500 rings)
Tax deduction (500 rings × 50 households × SEK 2,000 × 0.3 activity rate?)	SEK 15 million
Start-up grant (SEK 5,000 × 500 rings, one-time)	SEK 2.5 million
Security coordinator (100 municipalities × 0.5 FTE × SEK 500,000)	SEK 25 million
Training efforts (4 hrs × 500 participants per year × SEK 500/hr)	SEK 1 million
Digital platform (operation + support)	SEK 2 million
Evaluation	SEK 3 million
Total first year	**SEK 48.5 million**
Annual operation after scaling up	**SEK 46 million** (excl. start-up grant)

Financing: Compared to the police budget (SEK 35 billion/year), SEK 48.5 million is negligible. If the security rings reduce shootings by just 5% in the pilot areas, they have paid for themselves many times over (a single shooting costs society SEK 10–50 million in trials, healthcare, lost production).

Regulatory changes required

1. **New provision in the Income Tax Act (1999:1229)** – introduce a "security deduction" of SEK 2,000 per year for natural persons who actively participate in a registered security ring. The deduction is tax-free and does not affect other benefits.
2. **Ordinance on the registration of security rings** – the Swedish Tax Agency is tasked with establishing a simple digital register. Requirements: contact person, address, participant list, completed training.
3. **"Good Samaritan" law** – expand the civil law protection for persons who act in good faith to report suspected crime or intervene to prevent crime (similar to the model in several US states). This reduces the fear of legal consequences.
4. **Exemption from the Secrecy Act** – so that rings can share information among themselves and with the police's contact officer without violating GDPR or secrecy, introduce an exception in the Public Access to Information and Secrecy Act (OSL 2009:400) for "information exchange within the framework of a security ring".

Expected resistance and answers

"This is informing – neighbors snooping on each other."

Answer: The security ring is based on voluntary participation and clear rules. It is not about "snooping" but about caring. Seeing a youth being recruited to a gang and doing nothing is not integrity—it is indifference. The ring offers a structured way to act responsibly.

"The police will be flooded with tips – 99% will be garbage."

Answer: That is why the tips first go to the ring's coordinator (a neighbor) who filters and assesses the severity. Only well-founded, acute tips are forwarded to the police's contact officer. Furthermore, the current volume of tips from the public in vulnerable areas is extremely low—anything is better than today's silence.

"Integrity is threatened – neighbors see who is chatting."

Answer: The platform is encrypted and anonymized. Participants can choose to be anonymous to other members (only the coordinator sees the identity). And no one is forced to participate. Most people in vulnerable areas prioritize safety over anonymity.

"The costs are too high."

Answer: SEK 48.5 million is less than 0.14% of the police budget. And the rings do not replace the police—they make the police more effective by adding intelligence that otherwise does not exist. Socio-economically,

there is an extremely high return if just a few shootings are prevented.

"Are there any international examples?"

Answer: Yes. The UK's "Neighbourhood Watch" has similar models, but often without a digital platform. The US's "Crime Stoppers" uses anonymous tips successfully. Sweden's unique advantage is high digital competence and trust—we can build something better.

Swedish examples to build upon

- **Neighborhood watch (Grannsamverkan)** (the Police) – already exists in many areas, but is passive and lacks digital support. The security ring is an active, digital upgrade.
- **Night walks (Nattvandringar)** – many municipalities have volunteer night walkers. The security ring integrates them with a chat and tip function.
- **Support groups for vulnerable areas** (e.g., in Rinkeby, Rosengård) – exist informally, but not systematically. The security ring formalizes them.
- **Denmark's "Tryghedsgrupper"** – Denmark tests similar concepts with good results. Sweden can emulate this.

What you can do tomorrow

If you are a municipal politician: Submit a budget request for SEK 100,000 to start a pilot with 10 security rings in a vulnerable area. Use the text above as a basis.

If you are a police officer or local community actor: Gather interested neighbors in an area you know. Invite them to an information evening. Ask a retired police officer or security coordinator to lead the training (4 hours). Start a chat group.

If you are a citizen: Talk to your neighbors. Suggest a simple version—no platform, just a group chat in Signal or WhatsApp. Start by taking evening walks together. See what happens.

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Community mediators

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Summary: 100 respected local figures – coaches, religious leaders, grandmothers, former gang members – are recruited and trained in conflict mediation (200 hours). They receive a monthly salary of SEK 25,000 and work to intervene in disputes and recruitment attempts long before the police need to be involved. The goal: to create a credible, non-governmental actor that has legitimacy in the community and can resolve conflicts where police authority is insufficient.

The mechanism

Today, many conflicts in vulnerable areas escalate into shootings and deadly violence – not because the police do not want to intervene, but because police presence often lacks legitimacy. Residents do not trust the police, youth refuse to talk, and conflicts between groups are instead handled by gang leaders or informal "judges". The result: a parallel justice system that reinforces criminal structures.

The measure: Introduce **community mediators** – trusted individuals from the community who:

- Have high legitimacy in the area (know people, understand cultural codes, speak the same language)
- Are trained in conflict mediation, de-escalation, child and youth rights, and when the police must be involved
- Receive a salary (SEK 25,000/month) to work part-time or full-time actively going out into the area, listening to youth, identifying brewing conflicts, and mediating between parties
- Have a clear role: **intervene before violence** – not to replace the police in serious crimes, but to catch conflicts at a level where they can still be resolved through conversation and negotiation

What the mediator does (examples of tasks):

- Meets youth at youth centers, cafes, mosques, football pitches – listens to concerns, pulls strings.
- In a conflict between two families or youth groups: invites both parties to a mediation session (in a safe location, often a community hall or library).
- Negotiates a solution – an apology, repayment of stolen goods, one party changing schools – that is accepted by both.
- Documents the agreement (in writing or verbally) and follows up after a week, a month.

- If the conflict is too serious (weapons involved, threat of deadly violence) – involves the police's mediators or security coordinators.

Why the mediator works better than the police:

- **Legitimacy**: A grandmother in the area has an authority that the police lack. A former gang member can talk to youth in a way a uniformed police officer never can.
- **Early intervention**: The mediator catches conflicts while they are still small – before anyone has bought weapons or recruited friends.
- **Long-term perspective**: The mediator remains in the area after the conflict, building relationships and trust over time. Police officers are often rotated away.
- **Cost**: A mediator costs SEK 300,000/year (salary + payroll taxes). A police officer costs SEK 1.2–1.5 million/year. The mediator can handle many more conflicts per hour because they do not have the same bureaucracy.

Pilot design – 100 mediators first

Pilot phase 1 (years 1-3): 100 community mediators are hired in 20–30 municipalities with the greatest needs (high crime, vulnerable areas, perceived insecurity). The mediators are placed in areas where they already have roots and trust.

Selection process:

- The municipality or an independent foundation (e.g., Save the Children, Sweden's City Missions) is responsible for recruitment.
- Criteria: resident in or very close to the area, respected by different groups (youth, elderly, different ethnicities), good listening skills, no ongoing addiction or serious crime (but previous convictions do not disqualify – on the contrary, lived experience can be an asset).
- References from local associations, religious communities, sports clubs.

Training (200 hours distributed over 10 weeks or equivalent):

Module	Content	Hours
Conflict theory	Understanding conflict dynamics, the staircase of violence	20
Mediation techniques	Active listening, rephrasing, creating agreements	40
Child and youth rights	Laws concerning children, mandatory reporting, confidentiality	20
De-escalation	Handling threatening situations, avoiding violence	20

Module	Content	Hours
Cultural competence	Different norms, honor-related issues, religious aspects	20
Law	What are you allowed to do? When must the police be contacted?	20
Practicum	60 hours of fieldwork supervised by an experienced mediator	60
Total		**200**

Organizational model:

- The mediator is employed by the municipality, a non-profit association, or a cooperative – but must be independent from the police to maintain trust.
- Each mediator has a **supervisor** (experienced mediator or psychologist/social worker) for regular reflection and support.
- The mediator reports to a **mediation center** (municipal or regional) that ensures quality, assigns cases, and handles difficult situations.
- The mediator wears **no uniform** and carries no weapon. Their authority comes from the person, not from the state.

Evaluation:

- Number of mediations per mediator per month (target: 5–10 active conflicts)
- Proportion of mediations leading to an agreement (target: >80%)
- Proportion of agreements that hold after 3 months (follow-up)
- Change in the number of shootings, assaults, group violence in the area (compared to a control area)
- Surveys to youth, parents, and local actors regarding perceived security and trust

Budget and financing

Item	Annual cost (100 mediators)
Salaries (100 × SEK 25,000 × 12 months)	SEK 30 million
Payroll taxes (approx. 32%)	SEK 9.6 million
Training (200 hrs × SEK 500/hr × 100)	SEK 10 million (one-time first year)
Supervision (20 supervisors at 0.2 FTE)	SEK 2 million
Mediation center (administration, quality assurance)	SEK 3 million

Item	Annual cost (100 mediators)
Evaluation	SEK 2 million
Total first year	**SEK 56.6 million**
Annual operation after scale-up	**SEK 46.6 million** (excl. training)

Financing: Compared to the police budget (SEK 35 billion) or social services' costs for youth who commit crimes (several billion), SEK 56 million is a very small investment. If the mediators prevent just 10 serious shootings a year, they have saved society several hundred million kronor.

Regulatory changes required

1. **Amendment to the Social Services Act (2001:453)** – add a section: *"The social welfare committee may engage or employ community mediators to prevent and manage conflicts in residential areas. The mediator's task is to mediate in disputes that do not require police intervention."*

2. **The Secrecy Act** – the mediator must be able to promise confidentiality for parties to dare to speak. Introduce an exemption in the Public Access to Information and Secrecy Act (OSL) that protects the mediator's professional secrecy, with the same exceptions as for lawyers and psychologists (mandatory reporting upon suspicion of serious crimes against children remains).

3. **Act on Mediation Procedures** – a simple framework law defining what a mediation agreement is, how it is documented, and stating that it is not legally binding but can be invoked in court as evidence of the parties' intentions.

Expected resistance and answers

"This is letting criminals into the system – former gang members can continue their activities."

Answer: Recruitment must be meticulous. A previously convicted person who has left crime behind can be the most credible mediator for youth at risk. But background checks, probationary employment, and close supervision are required. The risk of relapse is small if the person has a meaningful job and social support.

"The police will feel bypassed – mediators are taking their jobs."

Answer: The mediator's job is to make the police's job possible. When conflicts are resolved early, the burden on the police decreases. And for serious crimes, the police are still the only ones with a monopoly on

violence. Mediators and police can collaborate: the mediator builds trust, the police investigate crimes.

"200 hours of training is not enough – mediation is a profession."

Answer: 200 hours is more than what most volunteer mediators have (often 40–80 hours). It is less than a social worker degree (3 years), but the mediator does not have the same responsibilities – they will not conduct investigations or make decisions on compulsory care. 200 hours is enough to learn basic mediation techniques and de-escalation, especially combined with a practicum.

"Is there a risk that the mediator themselves will be subjected to violence?"

Answer: Yes, there is some risk. Therefore, the mediator should never work alone in high-risk areas, always have an alarm function, and have access to supervision. Employer insurance covers injuries. But the risk is lower than for police officers, because the mediator does not wear a uniform and acts as a neutral party – not as an authority figure.

"Are there any international examples?"

Answer: Yes. The UK's "Violence Interrupters" (a model from Cure Violence, Chicago) uses former gang members to mediate conflicts – it has been shown to reduce shootings by 40–70% in pilot areas. Sweden already has small-scale examples (e.g., "Sluta skjut" in Malmö). Our model scales up and professionalizes this.

Swedish examples to build upon

- **Sluta skjut (Stop Shooting) (Malmö)** – a gang intervention method that uses mediators from civil society, but is limited to acute conflicts. Our model is preventive and broader.
- **Field assistants** – many municipalities have field workers who move among youth, but their mediation mandate is often unclear and underfunded. Community mediators are a specialized, better-trained version.
- **Mediation centers (Victim-Offender Mediation)** – have existed since 2008 for young offenders, but are reactive (after a crime). Community mediators are proactive (before a crime).
- **Norway's "Konfliktråd" (Conflict Councils)** – Norway has local conflict councils with mediators. Sweden can copy and adapt this.

What you can do tomorrow

If you are a municipal politician or an official in social services: Identify 2–3 people in your area who already act as informal mediators (an imam, a football coach, an engaged grandmother). Ask them if they would like training and a small compensation. Start a mini-pilot.

If you are an association leader or religious leader: Offer to be a test pilot for the training module. Help recruit candidates from your network.

If you are a researcher or evaluator: Contact an interested municipality and offer to follow a pilot with a randomized control group. Evidence of impact is crucial for scaling up.

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Municipal security budgets

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Summary: Every municipality receives SEK 100 per resident annually for security initiatives decided through participatory budgeting in the most vulnerable areas. The residents themselves prioritize between lighting, youth centers, security rings, mediators, de-escalation training, camera surveillance, or other local ideas. The goal: shift resources from reactive policing to preventive measures that actually create security – and let those who experience the insecurity decide what helps.

The mechanism

Today, security resources are governed from the top down. The police decide where patrols should go, the municipality decides on lighting, the state decides on grants for youth centers. Residents in vulnerable areas have almost no influence – even though they know best where the shoe pinches.

The measure: Introduce **municipal security budgets** with two components:

1. **A base budget** of SEK 100 per resident in the entire municipality (including all areas). This finances general security measures that benefit everyone – better lighting, park maintenance, public toilets, etc.

2. **A targeted budget** of an additional SEK 100 per resident in the areas classified as "vulnerable" or "particularly vulnerable" (according to the police list, or locally defined). This budget is distributed through **participatory budgeting**: the residents in the area vote on how the money should be used.

Participatory budgeting in practice:

- Every year in September, residents in the area gather for an idea market. Everyone who lives or works in the area (including children and youth) can submit proposals.
- The proposals are grouped into themes (lighting, youth activities, social interventions, physical environment) and cost-calculated by the municipality.
- In November, every resident (from 16 years of age, or from 13 years with parental permission) receives one vote per person. Voting takes place digitally or on-site in a library, school, or community center.
- The 5–10 proposals with the most votes are implemented during the coming year.
- A council of residents (drawn by lot) follows up to ensure that the money has been used as promised.

What the money can be used for (examples from other participatory budgets in the world):

Category	Examples of measures
Physical environment	Better lighting, tidying up parks, rubbish removal, bicycle stands, benches
Youth	Youth centers, night walks, summer jobs, sports activities, music studio
Social measures	Security rings, community mediators, neighborhood watch, elderly contact
Security	Camera surveillance (where residents want it), security walks, de-escalation training
Communication	Security app, information campaigns, neighborhood meetings

The difference compared to today's system:

Aspect	Today	Security budget
Who decides	Police, municipal officials, politicians	The residents themselves (through voting)
Resources	Earmarked, often reactive (police patrols)	Preventive, flexible
Transparency	Low (budgets are complex)	High (residents see directly where the money goes)
Accountability	Via elections every four years (impersonal)	Direct (council follows up, new voting every year)

Pilot design – 20 municipalities first

Pilot phase 1 (years 1-3): 20 municipalities of varying sizes and geography test security budgets in 1–3 vulnerable areas per municipality.

Selection criteria:

- The municipality has at least one area classified as "vulnerable" or "particularly vulnerable"
- The municipality shows political will (decision in the municipal council) and administrative capacity
- Geographical spread: large cities (Malmö, Gothenburg, Stockholm), medium-sized cities (Norrköping, Örebro, Gävle), smaller municipalities with vulnerable areas (Borlänge, Landskrona, Hässleholm)

Budget model:

Type	Per resident	Example municipality 100,000 res.	Example vulnerable area 5,000 res.
Base budget (entire municipality)	SEK 100	SEK 10 million	–
Targeted budget (vulnerable areas)	SEK 100	–	SEK 500,000 per area

Total for a municipality like Malmö (350,000 res., approx. 100,000 in vulnerable areas): SEK 35 million (base) + SEK 10 million (targeted) = SEK 45 million/year.

Organizational model:

- The municipality allocates the funds in its budget and transfers them to a **security fund** managed by an independent steering group (50% residents, 25% municipality, 25% civil society).
- A **security guide** (1 per area, 0.5 FTE) is responsible for supporting the participatory budgeting process – informing, collecting proposals, organizing voting, following up.
- The voting result is **binding** for the municipality – politicians cannot override the residents' decision. Exception: proposals that violate the law (e.g., buying weapons) or are obviously impossible to implement.

Evaluation:

- Participation rate: proportion of residents who submit proposals (target: >5%) and who vote (target: >30%)
- Implemented measures: proportion of the budget actually used as decided (target: >90%)
- Security effect: change in survey responses ("do you feel safe outdoors after dark?") compared to control areas
- Trust effect: change in trust in the municipality and the police

Budget and financing

Item	Annual cost (20 pilot municipalities)
Base budget (20 municipalities × average 50,000 res. × SEK 100)	SEK 100 million
Targeted budget (20 municipalities × average 2 vulnerable areas × 5,000 res. × SEK 100)	SEK 20 million

Item	Annual cost (20 pilot municipalities)
Security guides (40 areas × 0.5 FTE × SEK 500,000)	SEK 10 million
Administration, evaluation, platform	SEK 5 million
Total first year	**SEK 135 million**

Financing: Compared to the police budget (SEK 35 billion) or the state's grants to municipalities for security (several billion), SEK 135 million is a very small sum. The funds can be reallocated from existing appropriations for crime prevention work (Brå, National Board of Health and Welfare, the police's preventive funds). Socio-economically: if the measures reduce crime in the pilot areas by just 5%, the reform is self-financing.

Regulatory changes required

1. **Amendment to the Local Government Act (2017:725)** – add a section: *"The municipality may introduce participatory budgeting for security measures in particularly vulnerable areas. Decisions made through participatory budgeting shall be binding on the municipality, provided they fit within the budget and do not violate the law."*

2. **Ordinance on government grants for security measures** – reallocation of existing funds so that municipalities introducing security budgets are prioritized.

3. **The Secrecy Act** – for security guides to be able to handle personal data about participants (voting lists, etc.), clarification is required in the Public Access to Information and Secrecy Act (OSL). Normally these are municipal tasks – no major problem.

Expected resistance and answers

"Residents cannot prioritize – they will choose populist proposals that do not work."

Answer: Experiences from participatory budgeting in Paris, New York, and Porto Alegre show that residents prioritize wisely – often better than politicians. They choose schools, lighting, parks – not unnecessary projects. And even if a proposal is bad, one learns from mistakes. The point is to shift power, not to guarantee perfect decisions.

"This is expensive – SEK 100 per resident is a lot of money."

Answer: SEK 100 per resident is 0.1% of an average municipal budget (approx. SEK 100,000 per resident). It is less than what the municipality spends on information campaigns or anniversary celebrations. And compared to the costs of crime (SEK 200+ billion/year nationally), it is a negligible investment.

"Politicians do not want to give up control over the budget."

Answer: Then they will have to answer for why they do not trust their residents. Ultimately, it is about democracy – either you believe people can decide for themselves, or you don't. Security budgets are a concrete measure to reduce the gap between politicians and citizens.

"What happens if residents vote for camera surveillance that violates privacy?"

Answer: The proposal must be legal. Camera surveillance is permitted under certain conditions (crime prevention purpose, signage, privacy impact assessment). If residents vote for it – and it complies with the law – then it is a democratic decision. Better that the residents themselves choose surveillance than that the police or politicians impose it on them.

"Are there any Swedish examples?"

Answer: Yes, several municipalities have tested participatory budgeting on a small scale, e.g., Uppsala, Gothenburg ("framtidens Göteborg"), Stockholm (suburban projects). But no one has done it specifically for security in vulnerable areas with binding decisions. The pilot would make Sweden a pioneer.

Swedish examples to build upon

- **Participatory budgeting in Uppsala** – in 2019, Uppsala tested districts with SEK 1 million per area. The experiences were positive (high participation, satisfied residents). The scale model works.
- **Security surveys (Brå, SKR)** – municipalities already measure security today. The same data can be used for evaluation.
- **Municipal security councils** – exist in many municipalities, but are dominated by police and officials. Security budgets shift power to the residents.
- **Denmark's "tryghedsbudgetter" (security budgets)** – Denmark has tested similar concepts in vulnerable residential areas with good results (fewer reported crimes, higher security). Sweden can emulate this.

What you can do tomorrow

If you are a municipal politician: Submit a budget request to allocate SEK 100 per resident for participatory budgeting in a vulnerable area. Use the text above as a basis. Promise that you will respect the result – even if you do not agree.

If you are a municipal official: Propose to your manager that you carry out a smaller pilot with SEK 200,000 in a residential area. Let the residents vote between three proposals (e.g., lighting, youth center, security ring). Evaluate after one year.

If you are a resident in a vulnerable area: Gather your neighbors. Write a letter to the municipal executive board: "We want a security budget of SEK 100 per person – and we want to decide for ourselves how the money is used." The more people who sign, the harder it is for politicians to say no.

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Restorative justice

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Summary: For minor offenses – theft under SEK 5,000, vandalism, property damage, simple assault without serious injuries – a court can refer to mediation between victim and offender instead of prosecution. A trained mediator (community mediator or specially appointed person) leads a conversation where the offender gets to meet the victim, understand the consequences, apologize, and repair the damage (through work, repayment, or community service). If the agreement is fulfilled, the prosecution is dropped. The goal: reduce the burden on the justice system, increase the victim's redress, and reduce recidivism – at a fraction of the cost of prison or fines.

The mechanism

Today, even minor offenses are handled by a heavy, expensive, and slow legal process: police investigation, prosecutor, court, possibly prison or fines. The victim is often a bystander – the process is about punishing the offender, not about repairing the damage. The offender rarely learns why the action was wrong, and recidivism rates are high. At the same time, a single year in prison costs over SEK 1 million.

The measure: Introduce **restorative justice** as an alternative to the traditional legal process for minor offenses, where:

- The crime is admitted or proven (the perpetrator confesses or the evidence is clear)
- The victim consents to mediation (voluntary)
- The crime is of such a nature that prison is not required in the penalty scale (maximum penalty under 2 years, or obvious that the sanction would be fines/probation)
- A trained mediator (independent, often from civil society or a special mediation unit) leads the process

The process in steps:

1. The prosecutor assesses that the crime is suitable for restorative justice. Prosecution is not initiated immediately; instead, the case is sent to a **mediation center** (municipal or regional).
2. The mediator contacts the victim and the offender separately, explains the process, and asks if they want to participate (both must say yes).
3. The mediation takes place in a safe room – often in premises that are not a court (library, citizen center, community hall). The mediator leads the conversation, but the victim and the offender talk

directly to each other.

4. If the parties reach an agreement – e.g., the offender apologizes, pays damages, performs community service (cleaning a park, helping at a nursing home), or takes a conflict management course – it is written down and signed.
5. The agreement is followed up by the mediator after 1 month, 3 months, and 6 months. If it is fulfilled, the prosecutor drops the charges.
6. If the agreement is not fulfilled, or if any party changes their mind, the case goes back to the prosecutor for normal processing.

Why restorative justice works better:

Aspect	Traditional justice	Restorative justice
The victim's role	Bystander, often re-traumatized	Active party, receives redress
The offender's learning	Punished, but rarely understands why	Meets the victim, understands consequences
Recidivism	High (30–50% for youths)	Lower (studies show a 10–20% reduction)
Cost	High (trial, possibly prison)	Low (mediation costs SEK 5,000–15,000)
Time	Months to years	A few weeks
Societal effect	Division (victim isolated, offender labeled)	Healing (relationships are repaired)

Example: A 17-year-old boy has smashed a window at a school in frustration. Traditionally: police report, interrogation, prosecutor, court – fines (parents pay) or youth care. Restoratively: the boy meets the principal and the janitor who had to clean up. He apologizes, promises to repaint the fence as an extra effort, and writes a reflection on why he got angry. The principal accepts. Prosecution is dropped. The boy learns something. The school gets a painted fence.

Pilot design – 3 regions first

Pilot phase 1 (years 1-3): Three regions (e.g., Stockholm, Västra Götaland, Skåne) introduce restorative justice for selected crime types. The pilot area covers 5–10 municipalities per region.

Included crime types (exclusive list, can be expanded):

- Petty theft (max SEK 5,000)
- Vandalism (max SEK 10,000 in damage, no fire or dangerous object)
- Minor assault (bruises, scratches – no hospital care)
- Unlawful threat (lower degree, no weapon)

- Arbitrary conduct (e.g., taking someone's bicycle without permission)
- Burglary in a storage room or garage (lower degree)

Excluded crimes (always go to court):

- Violence with a weapon (knife, gun)
- Aggravated assault (broken bones, hospital stay)
- Sexual offenses
- Crimes against children under 15 years old
- Repeated serious criminality

Organizational model:

- The Swedish Prosecution Authority trains administrators to identify suitable cases.
- The mediation centers are established by the regions or municipalities in collaboration with civil society (e.g., Victim Support Sweden, Save the Children, local mediation centers).
- The mediators are recruited from experienced community mediators, social workers, psychologists, or lawyers – and undergo an 80-hour special training in restorative justice.
- An **independent review board** (with representatives from the police, prosecutors, victim organizations) quality-assures the mediation process and handles complaints.

Evaluation (compare with a control group taking the traditional route):

- Proportion of mediations leading to an agreement (target: >80%)
- Proportion of agreements fulfilled (target: >90%)
- Recidivism in crime within 1 year and 2 years (expected to be 10–20% lower than the control group)
- The victim's experience of justice and redress (survey scale 1–10)
- Cost per case (expected SEK 5,000–15,000 vs. SEK 30,000–100,000 for a court process)
- Processing time (expected 4–6 weeks vs. 4–6 months)

Budget and financing

Item	Annual cost (3 regions, an estimated 2,000 cases per year)
Mediation centers (3 × 1 center at SEK 2 million)	SEK 6 million
Mediators (fee per case SEK 5,000 × 2,000)	SEK 10 million
Training of mediators (80 hrs × 50 mediators × SEK 500/hr, one-time)	SEK 2 million

Item	Annual cost (3 regions, an estimated 2,000 cases per year)
Independent review board	SEK 1 million
Evaluation (research)	SEK 2 million
Total first year	**SEK 21 million**
Annual operation after scale-up	**SEK 17 million** (excl. training)

Financing: Compared to the court system's budget (approx. SEK 7 billion/year) or the prison and probation service's costs (SEK 11 billion/year), SEK 21 million is a very small investment. Every case that goes to mediation instead of court saves SEK 25,000–90,000. At 2,000 cases per year, the saving is SEK 50–180 million – the pilot pays for itself several times over.

Regulatory changes required

1. **Amendment to the Code of Judicial Procedure (1942:740)** – add a new section (RB 20:8a): *"If the crime is of a minor nature and the perpetrator has confessed, the prosecutor may refer the case to mediation according to the Act on Restorative Justice. Prosecution may only be initiated after the mediation has proven unsuccessful."*

2. **New Act on Restorative Justice** – defines the mediation process, the mediator's role, confidentiality, the victim's rights, the effect of agreements, and supervision.

3. **Exceptions to the Secrecy Act** – the mediator must be able to promise confidentiality. Exceptions from the Public Access to Information and Secrecy Act (OSL) for information that emerges during mediation (similar to lawyers and psychologists). Mandatory reporting upon suspicion of serious crimes remains.

Expected resistance and answers

"This is letting criminals go free – they should be punished, not talk."

Answer: The victim gets a chance for redress, the offender is forced to take responsibility in a way that prison never achieves. Studies show that recidivism decreases. Merely punishing without repairing is both expensive and inefficient. Restorative justice is not a "talk" – it is a demanding process with clear requirements for restitution.

"The victim may feel pressured to participate."

Answer: The mediation is completely voluntary for the victim. The victim is carefully informed of their rights and can cancel at any time. If the victim says no, the case goes to court as usual. However, many victims appreciate the opportunity to tell the perpetrator how the crime affected them.

"The offender might pretend to be remorseful to avoid punishment."

Answer: The mediator is trained to detect fake remorse. If the agreement is not fulfilled (e.g., the offender ignores the community service), the case returns to the prosecutor. And an agreement requires concrete actions (work, payment) – not just words.

"Prosecutors won't use this option – they are conservative."

Answer: That is why training and incentives are required. The pilot regions commit to using restorative justice in at least 5% of suitable cases. Over time, it becomes a natural part of the toolbox. Experiences from Norway and the UK show that prosecutors quickly become positive when they see the results.

"Are there international examples?"

Answer: Yes, many. New Zealand has used restorative justice for youths since 1989 ("Family Group Conferences") with very good results (recidivism reduced by 20–30%). The UK, Canada, and several US states have similar models. Norway introduced a law on restorative justice for youths in 2020. Sweden is lagging behind – the pilot can provide Swedish evidence.

Swedish examples to build upon

- **Victim-Offender Mediation (LVM)** – has existed since 2008 for young offenders, but is rarely used and is not linked to dropping charges. Our model provides clear legal status.
- **Young offenders – special processing** – social services can already conduct youth investigations, but the process is heavy. Restorative justice is smoother.
- **Mediation Center in Uppsala** – has existed for several years, but works mostly with family conflicts. The scale model exists.
- **Norwegian "konfliktråd" (conflict councils)** – Norway has local conflict councils handling restorative justice for youths. Sweden can copy the organization.

What you can do tomorrow

If you are a prosecutor or judge: Test informally – in a simple case (e.g., vandalism), suggest to the parties that they meet a mediator before the main hearing. If they reach an agreement, ask for a lesser penalty.

Document the result.

If you are a municipal politician or official: Contact the Swedish Prosecution Authority and offer to set up a mediation center in pilot form. Use the text above as a basis. Offer premises and mediators.

If you are a lawyer or social worker: Train to become a mediator in restorative justice (courses are available via, e.g., Victim Support Sweden, Save the Children, or international organizations). Become a resource in your region.

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Security centers

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Summary: Transform fortress-like police stations into integrated security centers—open, welcoming hubs where the police are part of a larger whole. A security center contains a police reception (max 30% of the area), mediation rooms, youth activities, legal help, mental health care, social services, and coordination of neighborhood watch. The staffing consists of 70% community workers (mediators, field workers, counselors, security guides) and 30% police officers. The goal: break the residents' distrust, create natural meeting places for informal intelligence exchange, and shift the focus from reactive crime fighting to preventive security building.

The mechanism

Today, police stations are often inaccessible, intimidating, and located in the periphery. In many vulnerable areas, the stations have been closed completely (Rosengård, Rinkeby, Bergsjön). Residents see the police as a distant, repressive force—not as a resource for security.

The measure: Convert existing police stations—or open new, smaller units—into **security centers** with the following design principles:

- **Open floor plan**: Entrance without security checks (except to the police workspaces). Cafe, seating, public restrooms. Doors are open during the daytime, evening hours at least three days a week.
- **Mixed staffing**: Police in uniform are visible, but they are a minority. The majority are community workers in civilian clothes—mediators, security guides, counselors, youth leaders, lawyers. They can be identified by a clear name tag, but no uniform.
- **Clear functions**:
    - *Police reception* (small) – to report crimes, leave tips, pick up passports. Separated from other areas for privacy.
    - *Mediation rooms* – safe, neutral rooms for conflict mediation, restorative justice, conversations between parties.
    - *Youth area* – billiards, computers, games, sofas. Staffed by youth leaders or field workers. Open after school hours.
    - *Legal advice* – drop-in with lawyers (non-profit or municipal) who help with leases, benefits, debts.
    - *Social services* – present on site at least two days a week. Meetings can be booked.

    - *Security guide* – a person who coordinates all actors, knows the resources in the area, and can guide residents correctly.
    - *Neighborhood area* – bookable room for associations, village communities, security rings. Can be used for meetings, coffee, activities.
- **Visible police presence without threat**: The police workspaces are separated but visible through glass walls. Residents see police working—it demystifies and creates trust. The police can also have an "open office" a few hours a week where anyone can stop by and talk.

How it creates security:

Problem today	Solution with security center
Residents don't dare go to the police station	The center is open, welcoming, mixed staffing – the threshold is lowered
The police have no local knowledge	The center is staffed by community workers who know the area and can guide the police right
Youth have no place to be	Youth area with adult role models – prevents recruitment
Conflicts escalate to violence	Mediation rooms are available immediately – no waiting time
Residents don't know where to turn	The security guide coordinates all actors – one entry point

Pilot design – 10 centers first

Pilot phase 1 (years 2-4): Ten existing or former police stations (or other municipal premises) in vulnerable areas are transformed into security centers. The selection is made in collaboration between the Swedish Police Authority, affected municipalities, and civil society.

Possible pilot locations (examples – can be varied):

Location	Status today	Potential
Rosengård, Malmö	Station closed 2018	Reopen as a center – symbolically important
Rinkeby, Stockholm	Station closed? (partially open)	Rebuild into a center
Bergsjön, Gothenburg	Small police presence, no station	New establishment in existing municipal premises
Södertälje (Hovsjö)	Police presence but closed station	Transform

Location	Status today	Potential
Botkyrka (Alby)	Former station, now other activity	Reclaim and rebuild
Norrköping (Hageby)	Small police station	Expand with community areas
Västerås (Bäckby)	Police presence, no station	New establishment
Helsingborg (Drottninghög)	Station exists, but is closed	Open up
Uppsala (Gottsunda)	Police presence, no station	New establishment in existing premises
Gävle (Andersberg)	Small police station	Expand

Organizational model:

- **Property owner**: The Swedish Police Authority (for existing stations) or the municipality (for new establishments). The premises are rented out to the center's operations at cost price.
- **Principal**: A foundation or cooperative that includes the Swedish Police Authority, the municipality, and civil society representatives (e.g., local associations, Victim Support Sweden). The board is appointed by these parties (one-third each).
- **Financing**: Operations are financed through a mix of police funds (for the police section), municipal funds (for social services, youth activities, guides), and state grants (for mediation, legal advice).
- **Staff**: Police officers (investigators, community police)—financed by the Swedish Police Authority. Community workers—financed by the municipality, region, or non-profit organizations.

Dimensioning keys (for a center serving 20,000 residents):

Function	Area (sqm)	Staff (full-time equivalents)
Police reception and office	150	4 police officers (community police, investigators)
Mediation rooms (2)	40	2 mediators (half-time)
Youth area	100	2 youth leaders
Legal advice	20	0.5 lawyer (non-profit + municipal)
Social services	30	1 social secretary (part-time)
Security guide	15	1 guide

Function	Area (sqm)	Staff (full-time equivalents)
Neighborhood area	50	(booked by external parties)
Cafe/meeting place	80	1 host (part-time)
Administration, tech	50	1 coordinator
Total	**535 sqm**	**approx. 12 full-time equivalents**

Evaluation:

- Number of visitors per week (target: >1,000 on average)
- Proportion of visitors who state they feel safer after visiting (survey scale)
- Number of tips to the police that come via the center (compared to previously)
- Change in perceived security in the area (security survey before/after)
- Change in the number of shootings, bombings, assaults (trends)

Budget and financing

Item	One-time cost (per center)	Annual operation (per center)
Rebuilding (535 sqm, medium standard)	SEK 5–10 million	–
Furnishings, equipment (furniture, computers, alarms)	SEK 1 million	–
Police staff (4 × SEK 1.2 million)	–	SEK 4.8 million
Community staff (8 × SEK 0.5 million average)	–	SEK 4.0 million
Rent, operations (electricity, cleaning, security)	–	SEK 1.5 million
Administration, coordination	–	SEK 1.0 million
Total per center	**SEK 6–11 million**	**SEK 11.3 million**
Total 10 centers	**SEK 60–110 million**	**SEK 113 million/year**

Financing: Compared to the police budget (SEK 35 billion) and the municipalities' social services budgets (over SEK 100 billion), SEK 113 million/year is a small investment. If just one center in Rosengård reduces

shootings by 10%, it has paid for itself many times over. The one-time cost can be financed through the reallocation of the police's investment funds or the municipalities' real estate budgets.

Regulatory changes required

1. **Amendment to the Police Ordinance (2014:1104)** – add a section: *"The Police Authority may, together with the municipality and civil society, establish security centers where police operations are co-located with social services, mediation, youth activities, and legal advice."*
2. **The Secrecy Act** – to enable information exchange between police, social services, and mediators within the center, introduce an exemption in the OSL (Public Access to Information and Secrecy Act) for "collaboration within the framework of a security center". Secrecy is only broken to prevent serious crime or acute danger.
3. **Exceptions to the Tenancy Act** – when the municipality or police rent out to non-profit associations at cost price or a subsidized price, they are exempted from the Public Procurement Act (LOU) because it is "internal collaboration" rather than procurement.

Expected resistance and answers

"The police shouldn't be running youth centers – it's not their job."

Answer: The police make up only 30% of the staff in the center. The main responsibility for the youth area, mediation, and legal advice lies with community workers, not police officers. The role of the police is to be available for urgent matters and build relationships—not to run leisure activities.

"This is too expensive – we can't afford it."

Answer: SEK 113 million per year for 10 centers is less than 0.3% of the police budget. And compared to the costs of gang violence (SEK 200+ billion/year), it is an extremely profitable investment if the centers contribute to reducing violence. Furthermore, existing premises can be used—in many areas, there are empty police stations and municipal premises.

"The police union will protest – police shouldn't collaborate with 'civilians'."

Answer: The union has been critical of the centralization that led to rotating duties and the loss of local anchoring. Security centers offer an opportunity for police to work on relationship-building in a team with other professionals—many police officers are asking for exactly this. It could become a recruitment advantage.

"Residents don't trust the police – they won't come to a center with police officers."

Answer: That is why only 30% of the staff are police officers. The entrance has no security checks, and one can visit the youth area, legal advice, or cafe without ever meeting a police officer. Trust is built gradually. Experiences from similar centers in the UK ("Police and Communities Together" – PACT) show that visits increase over time.

"Are there international examples?"

Answer: Yes. The UK's "One Stop Shop"—integrated service centers with police, social services, and housing companies. The US's "Community Service Centers" in Chicago and New York. The closest example is Norway's "Trygghetssenter" in Oslo (Tøyen)—open since 2019 with good results. Sweden can learn and do better.

Swedish examples to build upon

- **Previous attempts with local police stations** – before 2015, there were local stations with some collaboration. Security centers are an upgraded, more integrated version.
- **Citizen offices** – many municipalities have citizen offices where several authorities are co-located. Security centers expand this to police and mediation.
- **Field workers and youth clinics** – exist in many areas, but often separately from the police. Co-location creates synergies.
- **Norway's "Tøyen trygghetssenter"** – established in 2019 in a vulnerable area in Oslo. Contains police, social services, youth club, legal help. Evaluation shows increased security and reduced crime. Sweden should visit and copy this.

What you can do tomorrow

If you are a municipal commissioner or police chief: Book a study trip to Tøyen trygghetssenter in Oslo. Meet their staff. See how it works. Come home and propose a pilot in your municipality.

If you are a property owner in a vulnerable area: Donate or rent out a space at cost price to start a small security center in mini-format—a reception, a mediation room, a youth area. Start small.

If you are a local association leader: Write a letter to the police and the municipality: "We want a security center in our area. Here is a space we can use. Here are associations that can contribute staff." Show that the demand exists.

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This analysis is part of Swedish Subsidiarity's work toward a more distributed and resilient Sweden.
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